Ashwell and I manage to stick around and stick together into the afternoon and then into the evening, and, with the boos starting to subside, we take our score to 322 for four when bad light stops play. The following day, the third morning of the Test, we continue to make progress until, with our fifth-wicket partnership worth 212 runs in 74 overs, Ashwell is out for an excellent 149, his second century in as many Tests.

I am still not timing the ball as I would like and still not batting fluently, but at Headingley – as in Ahmedabad three and a half months earlier – I am digging in and building a score, accumulating runs. I reach 99, requiring just a single to reach a significant century eked out in adversity. The next over is a maiden. I face three balls in the following over, and block each delivery. Ten minutes pass. Twenty minutes pass. Twenty-five minutes pass.

To the growing amusement of my 'fans' on the Western Terrace, I seem to have got stuck on 99. The run remains frustratingly elusive and every dot ball that passes is being greeted by an ironic cheer. Another over goes by. Stay calm, I tell myself. Don't panic. I play and miss. It's now 34 minutes; it feels like 34 days.

Salvation arrives in the form of a single nudged to mid-off off Freddie Flintoff. I breathe deeply and, almost immediately, start to relax, start to time the ball and start to play some attacking strokes.

The runs are flowing now, and I take my score from 100 to 150 in just 54 balls. I move on to 178 before I finally edge a ball from Stuart Broad and am caught one-handed at slip by a flying Freddie Flintoff. It has been a significant innings for me, an ultimately rewarding eight and a half hours in the trenches.

We are eventually bowled out for 522, which means England start their second innings 319 runs behind. They wilt under the scoreboard pressure and are blasted out for 327. Our fast bowlers are charging in with real intent and I am pleased to support their efforts, managing to hold one of the best catches of my career, diving full length in the slips to dismiss Ian Bell.